

TECHNICAL & PROFESSIONAL COMMUNICATION

Applied Rhetorical Theory Worksheet & Reference Map

Project:

Authors:

Deadline:

Purpose

A clearly stated Purpose is the start of any project. Be specific with what rhetorical success looks like and what effect you want to generate.

Both Critical and Cultural Analysis approaches address flaws in the hyper-pragmatic nature of TPC. As such, they respectively extend the purpose of TPC works to include tackling political problems and understanding power-dynamics between stakeholders.

Genre is more than a set of rules or expectations. Genre is social action that acquires its meaning from social context, and it's use is liable to evolve or decay over time as organizations and attitudes change.

Anticipating the potential ways a TPC piece might circulate, either through a Social Justice lens or a Cultural Circuit model, can help address accommodation and representation issues that marginalized groups may have in engaging with your work.

Circulation & Rhetorical Velocity

Circulation involves anticipating the second- and third-order effects of a given piece. Consider how external organizations might interpret and transform your work and how it might cascade into unintended effects.

Kairos

What makes this the moment to engage with a particular discourse, otherwise known as Kairos?

Political situations and Social Action opportunities often have limited openings of Kairos. Understanding when the moment will pass is critical for timely, appropriate TPC responses.

Considering what powers control or influence the exigence of a work can help create a more accurate picture of current stakeholders to factor into ethical considerations.

Exigence

What is the problem behind the Purpose? Often related to solving a particular problem in TPC.

TPC should resist the urge for all constraints to be from a positivist, hyper-pragmatic perspective. Despite the need for clear, concise transmittal of information in TPC, consider that certain problems will require inventive artistic proofs as our understanding of epistemology shifts from the positivist view to a more culturally relative view as it concerns science.

Constraints

Cultural agents that can comprise an audience and affect your constraints extend beyond individuals or individual organizations. Power dynamics and imbalances between different groups impact what knowledge is considered legitimate and can lead to unseen economic or political considerations.

Audience

In TPC, your work is usually tailored towards a very specific audience. However, audience also includes the impact of your work on unintentional audiences throughout its circulation.

Analyzing an audience should include examining their values and contexts. TPC professionals have an opportunity with cultural analysis to critique the status quo and to ethically intervene in favor of identified marginalized groups.

TPC is overwhelmingly written from white, male perspectives, while the target audience may (and should) include much more diversity. Appealing to an audience should include seeking out sources outside of the hegemonic canon.

When trying to research or effect change in your Audience, researchers should frame the situation as unifying rather than adversarial. Work in concert with those involved and affected by your work.

Organizational constraints are socially and culturally constructed. Social Construct Theory can help identify constraints within an organization through participant observation, while cultural analysis theory can expand these constraints with enculturation to encompass a broader understanding of relevant restrictions that affect both targeted and unintentional audiences.

Constraints are the restrictions both positive and negative than impact the persuasive power and effectiveness of a piece of TPC communication.

Cultural Analysis Theory...

... understands that relationships between human and human-constructed systems that extend beyond any individual organization govern the power dynamics of transmitting technical information.

Social Construct Theory...

... stresses the central role that communities play in writing. According to this, all knowledge is communal and held in shared social constructs that exist only in organization with people around to interpret them.

Critical Theory...

... encourages political and social action through teaching and performing TPC, including but not limited to research involving feminism, racial education, and participatory action.

Humanistic Theory...

... approaches reject the purely positivist needs of transmitting technical information in favor of the liberal art of translating said information for both specific and general audiences.

Social Justice Theory...

... regarding TPC sees critical flaws in social equity between those in power and marginalized groups. It seeks to rectify areas of inequity as it concerns economic, retributive, and representation issues.

By: Garrett Richard Ferrara - Referenced works: Sullivan, Dale L. "Political Ethical Implications of Defining Technical Communication as a Practice."; Miller, Carolyn R. "A Humanistic Rationale for Technical Writing"; Thralls, Charlotte & Blyer, Nancy Roundy. "The Social Perspective and Pedagogy in Technical Communication"; Blyer, Nancy R. "Taking a Political Turn: The Critical Perspective and Research in Professional Communication"; Scott, J. Blake | Longo, Bernadette | Wills, Katherine V. "Why Cultural Studies?"; Longo, Bernadette. "An Approach for Applying Cultural Study Theory to Technical Writing."; Scott, J. Blake. "Tracking Rapid HIV Testing through the Cultural Circuit: Implications for Technical Communication."; Walton, Rebecca | Moore, Kristen R. | Jones, Natasha N. "Technical Communication After the Social Justice Turn."; Miller, Carolyn R. "Genre as Social Action".